



MONTHLY UPDATE

Eswatini: monthly update, July – August 2026

Edition of 2026-08-25 · 35 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY
· CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

Summary of the month

Eswatini's World Bank digital financing was [approved at more than E1.06bn on 19 July 2026](#) for a fibre backbone, connectivity for 1,031 public institutions and electronic identity by 2027. In the same weeks the data-protection authority [moved into sectoral rule-making](#), the National Data Governance Policy [reached validation](#), the regulator [proposed raising the minimum internet speed fivefold](#), and a parliamentary committee [put the price of a bank transaction on the record](#). The sponsoring ministry also [stated that data-protection enforcement is not its mandate](#) while announcing an instrument carrying data-protection duties.

Governance

Strategies, plans and policies

The National Data Governance Policy [was validated on 27 July 2026](#) by stakeholders from government, business, civil society, academia and development partners, with a stated cycle of 2027 to 2031 — a policy dated to begin the year after it was drafted. Support runs through the Team Europe Data Governance in Africa initiative, the same channel behind the April 2026 workshop. The text is not published and no adoption date is given.

Legislation and regulation

In the same 4 August answer, the ICT ministry said it had completed the Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026, introducing a registration requirement for online publishers bound to accuracy, privacy protection, child safeguarding and the responsible use of AI. Neither the text nor a commencement date is public.

Data protection

The next day ESCCOM, as the data protection authority, [began validating draft advisory guidelines on the lawful processing of personal health data](#) at Ezulwini, with the health ministry, providers, insurers, pharmacies and medical aid schemes. They will be published as a regulatory instrument under the Data Protection Act 2022, covering collection, retention, sharing, breach notification, cloud services and patient rights. The commission disclosed that it has concluded a complaint over a practitioner's unlawful disclosure of a patient's information.

In August the same rule-making reached a second sector and produced a ranking. A week-long workshop [validated draft sector data-protection guidelines and produced a proposed whistle-blower-protection framework, with the regulator naming the financial sector as the leading source of personal-data breaches](#) — through misdirected statements and invoices, and cybersecurity incidents exposing customer records. No breach count, penalty or enforcement action is published behind the ranking, and the draft guidelines are not held.

Standards

Asked on 4 August how online publications comply with the data-protection law, the ICT ministry [answered that implementation, enforcement and oversight do not fall within its direct mandate](#) but are vested in ESCCOM.

Finance

New investments

The month's largest item is the financing: the ICT ministry's first-quarter performance report established that Eswatini has [secured approval for more than E1.06bn in World Bank financing for the Digital Eswatini Project](#), converted in the source at E16.37 to the dollar on 19 July 2026.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

ESCCOM [proposed on 20 July 2026, in Notice 08/2026, raising the minimum internet speed from 2 Mbps to 10 Mbps](#), citing demand for high-bandwidth low-latency service. It is a proposal; the 2 Mbps standard stands.

At a workshop for ICT parastatal directors on 22 July, the Ministry of ICT [put mobile coverage at 95% and mobile-internet subscription at 57%](#), blaming data prices and paper-based public services, and set out a target of 859 schools and 134 health facilities to be connected. It named institutional leadership, not technology, as what will decide the outcome.

Free adjudication of consumer complaints against communications providers runs under the Eswatini Communications Commission Act 2013, with windows of one month for post and courier, three for broadcasting and six for telecommunications — a structural provision, not dated state.

Cybersecurity

On 30 July the SADC Committee of Central Bank Governors subcommittee on banking supervision, meeting at Ezulwini, [approved regional frameworks on cybersecurity, climate-related financial risk and cross-border crisis management](#). The Central Bank of Eswatini governor urged supervisors to extend oversight to cloud hosting providers, payment processors and AI used in credit scoring.

DPI

Digital Payments and Fintech

Three days after the FinScope survey launch, a Ministry of Finance portfolio committee [reported charges differing between institutions for equivalent services and higher than comparable banks in the sub-region](#), recommending the central bank benchmark them against SACU and Common Monetary Area banks within 30 days of adoption. The dated figure on the record is a withdrawal of E4,000 attracting E79 to E89 in fees; the ministry replied that the bank concerned had not raised charges but moved to real-time display of each fee.

Cross-border, an account published on 21 July established two things by implication. Eswatini's central bank governor [discussed leveraging Egyptian experience to accelerate PAPSS accession](#), which places Eswatini outside PAPSS as at that date. The same account reports low-value Common Monetary Area transactions migrating off domestic electronic-funds-transfer rails onto the TCIB scheme, with no timetable, volume, value or mandating instrument given.

Registries

On identity, a proposal to [require DNA testing before issuing birth certificates was costed at about E126m a year, roughly 46% of the Home Affairs budget](#) — about E4,300 per test across about 29,400 births.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The state's auditor put artificial intelligence at the centre of its own next four years. The Auditor-General [launched a strategic plan for 2026 to 2030 naming artificial intelligence and digital transformation as the route to stronger public-sector accountability, urging more than 80 audit officers to adopt them](#), developed with the INTOSAI Development Initiative and the African organisation of English-speaking supreme audit institutions. The plan text is not held, and no tool, data access, assurance standard or safeguard for audit use of artificial intelligence is stated — in a country whose national artificial-intelligence strategy is recorded as *Not held*.

Digitalisation

Digitalisation of sub-national government

The same Digital Eswatini connectivity target names 38 tinkhundla centres to be connected, none reported connected as at 22 July ([source](#)).

Rural digital data capture

Rural data collection got hardware rather than a system. The agriculture ministry [handed 40 tablets and 4 laptops, valued at E313,504, to agricultural extension officers on 10 August](#) under an IFAD and Green Climate Fund-backed project, for real-time crop, livestock and weather reporting by officers working with smallholder farmers across all four regions. No officer total, data platform, reporting standard or custodian for the collected field data is stated, so what the reports feed into is not on the record.

Technology

AI

Eswatini's second instrument to carry AI rules arrived in the month, and like the first it is not an AI instrument: the [Online Media Publishing Guidelines 2026 bind registered publishers to the responsible use of AI](#), enforced through the registration requirement they create. There is still no national AI strategy or statute behind either.

On 6 July the prime minister told the [Global Dialogue on AI Governance in Geneva that small and developing nations should not become mere consumers of technologies developed elsewhere](#), an address the National 4IR Strategy frames.

[A regional health body and a private firm signed a memorandum in Eswatini on 4 August to scale AI-enabled health solutions](#), naming no system, no data-sharing terms and no money.

ICT Industry

Domestically, [Letshego Eswatini set out plans to expand digital banking to the unbanked](#) following the grant of a provisional banking licence.

Innovation ecosystem

[Digital transformation was named a priority of the Eswatini-Taiwan relationship](#) at a leaders' meeting in Taipei, with no instrument, figure or implementing agency named; the meeting's own date is not established.

Capacity

Training and skills

At the Macetjeni handover the ICT ministry's principal secretary said [AI, robotics, coding and cybersecurity courses would follow](#) at the innovation hubs.

The hub itself opened on 6 August at Macetjeni in the Lubombo Region, [the second of its kind, backed by the development programme with the communications regulator and the small-enterprise development company and aimed at young people, women and people with disabilities](#). It opens against an internet-usage rate of 58% and youth unemployment of 56%. No intake target, running cost or funding term is published, so what a second hub is expected to change cannot be read from the account.

Inclusion

Access to services

The country's second innovation hub opened at [Macetjeni in the Lubombo region on 7 August, extending digital-skills and small-business support to a rural community](#), built by the small enterprise development company with the communications commission and UNDP under a youth empowerment programme, and following the Pigg's Peak hub of 2025. No financing figure was disclosed for the facility, and no user, training or enterprise-support count is published for either.

What firms say they need is not more hubs but a network that stays up. At a Mbabane panel on 7 August, logistics, renewable-energy and creator-economy speakers [argued that unreliable connectivity is now a direct cost to business, outweighing any saving from cheaper data](#), describing real-time fleet tracking, remote solar-system monitoring and social-platform market access as core to operations, and urged investment in rural connectivity to widen economic participation. It is a panel of interested parties, and the base holds no reliability series to test it against.

Digital divides

On 6 August the [Macetjeni Integrated Business, Employment and Innovation Hub was launched in the Lubombo Region](#), the second after Pigg's Peak, established by the Small Enterprises Development Company with ESCCOM and UNDP. A third hub is in preparation for Shiselweni, with no start date, provider or cohort size given.

Data

National statistics

The central bank [launched the FinScope Eswatini 2026 Consumer Survey on 24 July](#) with ESEPARC, the Central Statistical Office and FinMark Trust. [Its governor said the 87% access rate recorded in 2018 measured access rather than use, and that the 2026 round will cover access, usage and quality – the first measurement since the Consumer Credit Act, the payment switch and the FinTech Strategy changed the stack.](#) No fieldwork dates, sample size or publication date were given.

Geopolitics

US / hyperscaler activities

The [partnership with the cloud provider is operating and publicly acknowledged, with the government services application showcased at the provider's Africa summit.](#) No value or term is published, so what the state has committed to, and for how long, is not established.

Gulf/UAE activities

On 22 July the [She Powers Africa Digital Academy launched virtually](#) under an Eswatini-UAE memorandum signed at the 2025 UN General Assembly. Delivery is by the UAE's General Women's Union with its telecommunications regulator, covering AI, cybersecurity, data science and software development. The first cohort is 50 women from government institutions.

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